paragraph. I was a smash. Then I finished up with my new line at the end: “I’ve talked about the continuing threat of fascism in the postwar world, but there’s another ‘ism,’ Communism, and if I ever find evidence that Communism represents a threat to all that we believe in and stand for, I’ll speak out just as harshly against Communism as I have fascism.” Then I walked off the stage—to a dead silence.

A few days later, I received a letter from a woman who said she’d been in the audience that night. “I have been disturbed for quite some time,” she said, “suspecting there is something sinister happening in that organization that I don’t like.” Then she added: “I’m sure you noticed the reaction to your last paragraph when you mentioned Communism. I hope you recognize what that means. I think the group is becoming a front for Communists. I just wanted you to know that that settled it for me. I resigned from the organization the next day.”

Thanks to my minister and that lady, I began to wake up to the real world and what was going on in my own business, the motion picture industry.

There were then forty-three labor unions in the picture business. A few were independents but most were affiliated with the American Federation of Labor. The Screen Actors Guild was one of the latter, as was the International Association of Theatrical and Stage Employees—better known as the stagehands’ union or by its initials, IATSE.

During the absence of so many of us during the war something new had come into being. Some of the unions had gotten together to organize what they called the “Conference of Studio Unions,” also known as CSU.

The IATSE had recovered from a prewar crisis in which Chicago mobsters had taken it over and extorted under-the-table payoffs from studio officials while also trying to create an actors’ union in opposition to the Screen Actors Guild. This was before my time but I learned about it from the